

ADVANCE MONTHLY SALES FOR RETAIL AND FOOD SERVICES, APRIL 2017

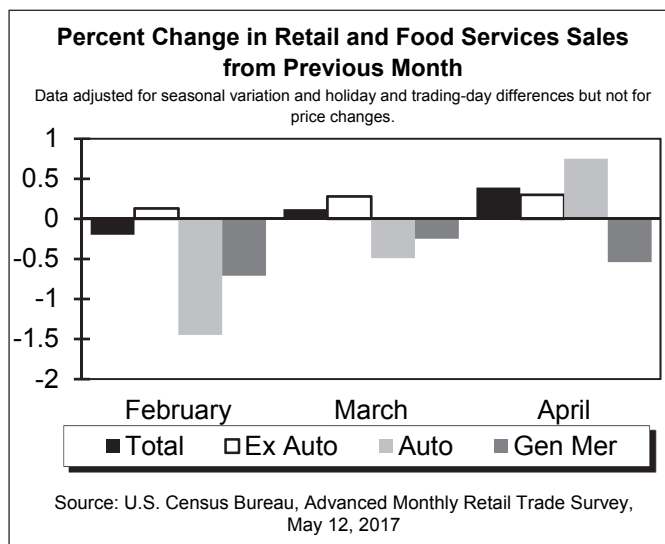
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Notice of Revision: Monthly retail sales estimates were revised on April 26, 2017 based on the results of the 2015 Annual Retail Trade Survey. The Annual Revision of Monthly Retail and Food Services showing revised estimates can be found on our website at:

<<https://www.census.gov/retail/mrts/www/benchmark/2017/html/annrev17.html>>.

May 12, 2017 — The U.S. Census Bureau announced the following advance estimates of U.S. retail and food services sales for April 2017:

ADVANCE MONTHLY SALES		
April 2017	\$474.9 billion	0.4%*
March 2017 (revised)	\$473.1 billion	0.1%*
Next release: June 14, 2017		
* The 90 percent confidence interval includes zero. There is insufficient statistical evidence to conclude that the actual change is different from zero.		
Data adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences but not for price changes. Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advanced Monthly Retail Trade Survey, May 12, 2017.		



Advance Estimates of U.S. Retail and Food Services

Advance estimates of U.S. retail and food services sales for April 2017, adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences, but not for price changes, were \$474.9 billion, an increase of 0.4 percent (± 0.5 percent)* from the previous month, and 4.5 percent (± 0.9 percent) above April 2016. Total sales for the February 2017 through April 2017 period were up 4.7 percent (± 0.7 percent) from the same period a year ago. The February 2017 to March 2017 percent change was revised from down 0.2 percent (± 0.5 percent)* to up 0.1 percent (± 0.2 percent)*.

Retail trade sales were up 0.4 percent (± 0.5 percent)* from March 2017, and up 4.5 percent (± 0.7 percent) from last year. Gasoline Stations sales were up 12.3 percent (± 1.4 percent) from April 2016, while Nonstore Retailers were up 11.9 percent (± 1.8 percent) from last year.

Data Inquiries

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General Information

The May 2017 Advance Monthly Retail report is scheduled for release on June 14, 2017 at 8:30 a.m. EDT. View the full schedule in the Economic Briefing Room: www.census.gov/economic-indicators/. The full text and tables of this release can be found at www.census.gov/retail/.

EXPLANATORY NOTES

The advance estimates are based on a subsample of the Census Bureau's full retail and food services sample. A stratified random sampling method is used to select approximately 4,700 retail and food services firms whose sales are then weighted and benchmarked to represent the complete universe of over three million retail and food services firms.

Survey Description

The U.S. Census Bureau conducts the Advance Monthly Retail Trade and Food Services Survey to provide an early estimate of monthly sales by kind of business for retail and food service firms located in the United States. Each month, questionnaires are mailed to a probability sample of approximately 4,700 employer firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey. Advance sales estimates are computed using a link relative estimator. For each detailed industry, we compute a ratio of current-to-previous month weighted sales using data from units for which we have obtained usable responses for both the current and previous month. For each detailed industry, the advance total sales estimates for the current month is computed by multiplying this ratio by the preliminary sales estimate for the previous month (derived from the larger MRTS) at the appropriate industry level. Total estimates for broader industries are computed as the sum of the detailed industry estimates. The link relative estimate is used because imputation is not performed for most nonrespondents in MARTS. For a limited number of nonresponding companies that have influential effects on the estimates, sales may be estimated based on historical performance of that company. The monthly estimates are benchmarked to the annual survey estimates from the Annual Retail Trade Survey once available. The estimates are adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading day differences. Additional information on MARTS and MRTS can be found on the Census Bureau website at: www.census.gov/retail/.

Reliability of Estimates

Because the estimates presented in this report are based on a sample survey, they contain sampling error and nonsampling error.

Sampling error is the difference between the estimate and the result that would be obtained from a complete enumeration of the sampling frame conducted under the same survey conditions. This error occurs because only a subset of the entire sampling frame is measured in a sample survey. Standard errors and coefficients of variation (CV), as given in Table 3 of this report, are estimated measures of sampling variation.

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The margin of sampling error, as used on page 1, gives a range about the estimate which is a 90 percent confidence interval. If, for example, the percent change estimate is +1.2 percent and its estimated standard error is 0.9 percent, then the margin of sampling error is $\pm 1.753 \times 0.9$ percent or ± 1.6 percent, and the 90 percent confidence interval is -0.4 percent to +2.8 percent. If the interval contains 0, then one does not have sufficient evidence to conclude at the 90 percent confidence level that the change is different from zero and therefore the change is not statistically significant. Estimated changes shown in the text are statistically significant unless otherwise noted. For a monthly total, the median estimated coefficient of variation is given. The resulting confidence interval is the estimated value $\pm 1.753 \times CV \times$ (the estimated monthly total). The Census Bureau recommends that individuals using estimates in this report incorporate this information into their analyses, as sampling error could affect the conclusions drawn from the estimates.

Nonsampling error encompasses all other factors that contribute to the total error of a sample survey estimate. This type of error can occur because of nonresponse, insufficient coverage of the universe of retail businesses, mistakes in the recording and coding of data, and other errors of collection, response, coverage, or processing. Although nonsampling error is not measured directly, the Census Bureau employs quality control procedures throughout the process to minimize this type of error.

America's Economy Mobile App

The America's Economy app provides real-time updates for 19 key economic indicators released from the Census Bureau, Bureau of Labor Statistics, and Bureau of Economic Analysis.

[<www.census.gov/mobile/economy/>](http://www.census.gov/mobile/economy/)

API

The Census Bureau's application programming interface lets developers create custom apps to reach new users and makes key demographic, socio-economic and housing statistics more accessible than ever before.

[<www.census.gov/developers/>](http://www.census.gov/developers/)

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Table 1. Estimated Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Total sales estimates are shown in millions of dollars and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS ¹ code	Kind of Business	Not Adjusted						Adjusted ²					
		4 Month Total		2017			2016		2017			2016	
		2017	% Chg. 2016	Apr. ³ (a)	Mar. (p)	Feb. (r)	Apr.	Mar.	Apr. ³ (a)	Mar. (p)	Feb. (r)	Apr. (r)	Mar. (r)
	Retail & food services,												
	total	1,794,341	3.5	466,734	484,144	420,352	452,609	461,954	474,948	473,102	472,513	454,696	451,274
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ...	1,417,565	3.7	369,540	378,230	331,342	355,999	361,902	377,805	376,679	375,618	361,647	359,134
	Retail	1,572,581	3.6	408,741	424,907	368,259	395,883	405,761	418,314	416,686	416,196	400,204	397,086
	GAFO⁴	(*)	(*)	(*)	102,910	91,190	98,468	103,723	(*)	105,272	104,720	105,191	104,971
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	376,776	3.0	97,194	105,914	89,010	96,610	100,052	97,143	96,423	96,895	93,049	92,140
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers .	347,893	3.4	89,795	97,906	82,318	89,102	92,044	89,616	88,925	89,573	85,593	84,677
44111	New car dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	79,712	67,655	73,115	75,491	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4413	Auto parts, acc. & tire stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	8,008	6,692	7,508	8,008	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	35,163	2.2	8,707	9,772	8,336	8,632	9,233	9,464	9,515	9,377	9,115	9,043
4421	Furniture stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	5,269	4,585	4,653	5,069	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4422	Home furnishings stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	4,503	3,751	3,979	4,164	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
443	Electronics & appliance stores	29,087	-3.0	6,955	7,704	7,078	6,965	7,833	8,211	8,103	7,929	8,157	8,235
44311, 13	Appl., T.V. & camera.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	5,624	5,134	5,335	5,884	(*)	5,932	5,795	6,125	6,207
44312	Computer & software stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	(S)	(S)	(S)	(S)	(*)	(S)	(S)	(S)	(S)
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	113,651	5.9	34,198	31,451	24,129	32,342	29,874	31,245	30,864	31,402	28,576	29,628
4441	Building mat. & sup. dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	26,855	21,245	26,944	25,519	(*)	26,775	27,098	24,948	25,673
445	Food & beverage stores.....	229,082	1.5	58,411	59,540	53,865	56,375	58,170	59,422	59,583	59,157	58,073	57,406
4451	Grocery stores	206,244	1.3	52,299	53,530	48,490	50,627	52,336	52,988	53,211	52,821	51,978	51,310
4453	Beer, wine & liquor stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	4,183	3,703	4,075	4,017	(*)	4,445	4,419	4,317	4,301
446	Health & personal care stores	107,491	-0.9	26,898	28,464	25,565	27,063	28,427	27,673	27,448	27,255	27,475	27,281
44611	Pharmacies & drug stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	23,245	21,126	22,648	23,550	(*)	22,437	22,403	22,970	22,601
447	Gasoline stations	142,073	14.3	37,858	37,372	32,597	33,975	32,373	38,163	38,096	38,259	33,975	33,034
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	75,250	-1.1	20,666	21,028	17,856	20,311	21,350	21,389	21,504	21,111	21,287	21,242
44811	Men's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	766	617	734	707	(*)	791	737	719	708
44812	Women's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	3,395	2,684	3,534	3,644	(*)	3,274	3,285	3,418	3,415
44814	Family clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	8,113	6,343	7,795	8,285	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4482	Shoe stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	3,143	2,626	2,850	3,164	(*)	3,037	2,895	2,978	2,938
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book & music stores.....	25,298	-4.1	6,463	6,781	5,676	6,687	7,084	7,295	7,252	7,277	7,472	7,512
452	General merchandise stores.....	209,026	-0.3	53,903	55,421	50,223	53,481	55,829	56,162	56,466	56,605	56,534	56,337
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.).....	43,370	-5.2	11,725	11,922	10,169	11,868	12,580	12,596	12,569	12,553	13,074	13,127
4521	Department stores (incl. L.D.) ⁵	(*)	(*)	(*)	12,312	10,405	12,159	12,981	(*)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4529	Other general merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	43,499	40,054	41,613	43,249	(*)	43,897	44,052	43,460	43,210
45291	Warehouse clubs & supercenters.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	37,410	34,697	36,037	37,289	(*)	37,826	38,087	37,578	37,401
45299	All oth. gen. merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	6,089	5,357	5,576	5,960	(*)	6,071	5,965	5,882	5,809
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	39,070	3.4	10,119	10,443	9,354	10,154	10,060	10,796	10,790	10,833	10,602	10,278
454	Nonstore retailers	190,614	10.7	47,369	51,017	44,570	43,288	45,476	51,351	50,642	50,096	45,889	44,950
4541	Elect. shopping & m/o houses	(*)	(*)	(*)	43,799	37,891	37,272	38,819	(*)	44,376	43,906	39,651	39,093
722	Food services & drinking places ...	221,760	3.2	57,993	59,237	52,093	56,726	56,193	56,634	56,416	56,317	54,492	54,188

(*) Advance estimates are not available for this kind of business. (NA) Not available (a) Advance estimate (p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(S) Estimate does not meet publication standards because of high sampling variability (coefficient of variation is greater than 30%), poor response quality (total quantity response rate is less than 50%), or other concerns about the estimate's quality.

(1) For a full description of the NAICS codes used in this table, see <http://www.census.gov/eos/www/naics>

(2) Estimates are concurrently adjusted for seasonal variation and for holiday and trading day differences, but not for price changes. Concurrent seasonal adjustment uses all available unadjusted estimates as input to the X-13ARIMA-SEATS program. The factors derived from the program are used in calculating all seasonally adjusted estimates shown in this table. Year-to-date seasonally adjusted sales estimates are not tabulated. Adjustment factors and explanatory material can be found on the Internet at <http://www.census.gov/retail>

(3) Advance estimates are based on early reports obtained from a small sample of firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey (MRTS) sample. All other estimates are from the MRTS sample.

(4) GAFO represents firms which specialize in department store types of merchandise and is comprised of furniture & home furnishings (442), electronics & appliances (443), clothing & accessories (448), sporting goods, hobby, book, and music (451), general merchandise (452), office supply, stationery, and gift stores (4532).

(5) Estimates include data for leased departments operated within department stores. Data for this line are not included in broader kind-of-business totals.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, May 12, 2017. Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at www.census.gov/retail/how_surveys_are_collected.html.

Table 2. Estimated Change in Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS code	Kind of Business	Percent Change ¹					
		Apr. 2017 Advance from --		Mar. 2017 Preliminary from --		Feb. 2017 through Apr. 2017 from --	
		Mar. 2017 (p)	Apr. 2016 (r)	Feb. 2017 (r)	Mar. 2016 (r)	Nov. 2016 through Jan. 2017	Feb. 2016 through Apr. 2016
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.4	4.5	0.1	4.8	0.6	4.7
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ...	0.3	4.5	0.3	4.9	1.2	4.8
	Retail	0.4	4.5	0.1	4.9	0.6	4.8
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	0.7	4.4	-0.5	4.6	-1.6	4.2
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers ..	0.8	4.7	-0.7	5.0	-1.5	4.6
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	-0.5	3.8	1.5	5.2	2.1	4.1
443	Electronics & appliance stores	1.3	0.7	2.2	-1.6	1.4	-1.7
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	1.2	9.3	-1.7	4.2	3.2	7.1
445	Food & beverage stores.....	-0.3	2.3	0.7	3.8	0.7	2.9
4451	Grocery stores	-0.4	1.9	0.7	3.7	0.6	2.7
446	Health & personal care stores	0.8	0.7	0.7	0.6	1.0	0.3
447	Gasoline stations	0.2	12.3	-0.4	15.3	2.3	16.1
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	-0.5	0.5	1.9	1.2	-1.1	-0.1
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book & music stores.....	0.6	-2.4	-0.3	-3.5	1.4	-2.8
452	General merchandise stores.....	-0.5	-0.7	-0.2	0.2	-0.2	0.1
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.).....	0.2	-3.7	0.1	-4.3	0.0	-4.5
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	0.1	1.8	-0.4	5.0	0.9	4.7
454	Nonstore retailers	1.4	11.9	1.1	12.7	2.8	12.1
722	Food services & drinking places	0.4	3.9	0.2	4.1	1.0	3.9

(p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(1) Estimates shown in this table are derived from adjusted estimates provided in Table 1 of this report.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, May 12, 2017. Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <www.census.gov/retail/how_surveys_are_collected.html>

Table 3. Estimated Measures of Sampling Variability and Revision to Advance Estimates Apr. 2017

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey and Monthly Retail Trade Survey)

NAICS Code	Kind of Business	Median CV ⁽¹⁾ for Current Mo. (%)	Median standard error ⁽¹⁾ for Percent change			Revision for month- to-month change ⁽²⁾	
			Previous Mo. to Current Mo.	Previous Qtr. to Current Qtr.	Current Mo. to same Mo. Last Yr.	Average revision	Median absolute revision
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.6	0.3	0.2	0.5	0.1	0.2
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ..	0.7	0.2	0.2	0.5	0.1	0.1
	Retail	0.6	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.1	0.2
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	1.3	0.9	0.4	1.2	0.1	0.6
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers .	1.4	1.0	0.4	1.3	0.1	0.6
442	Furniture & home furn. stores.....	2.6	1.0	0.8	1.4	0.2	0.9
443	Electronics & appliance stores	2.9	0.6	0.6	2.1	-0.2	0.3
444	Building material & garden eq. &.....						
	supplies dealers.....	2.2	0.8	0.7	1.0	0.2	0.7
445	Food & beverage stores.....	1.5	0.2	0.2	0.5	0.0	0.2
4451	Grocery stores	1.6	0.2	0.2	0.5	0.1	0.2
446	Health & personal care stores	2.9	0.4	0.7	2.9	0.1	0.3
447	Gasoline stations	1.8	0.5	0.3	0.8	0.3	0.3
448	Clothing & clothing accessories						
	stores	2.3	0.5	0.4	0.7	-0.1	0.2
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book &						
	music stores.....	2.5	1.3	0.7	1.2	-0.1	0.4
452	General merchandise stores.....	0.2	0.0	0.0	0.1	-0.1	0.2
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.).....	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.1
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	3.0	2.6	1.4	2.8	0.0	0.7
454	Nonstore retailers	1.7	0.5	0.4	1.0	0.2	0.4
722	Food services & drinking places ..	2.2	1.1	0.7	1.4	0.2	0.3

(1) Estimated measures of sampling variability are based on estimates not adjusted for seasonal variation or holiday or trading day variation.

Medians are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.

(2) These columns provide measures of the difference between the advance-to-preliminary and preliminary-to-final estimates of month-to-month change for the same pair of months as measured by the Advance sample and MRTS sample. The average and median revisions are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, May 12, 2017. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <www.census.gov/retail/how_surveys_are_collected.html>.